Maulana A. Balangi

Maulana A. Balangi, more widely known by his popular name **Alan Balangi-Amer** (born in Tamparan, Lanao del Sur), is a Maranao peace advocate, human rights defender, and civic leader who has spent more than two decades in the thick of the struggle for Bangsamoro self-determination and justice. He is the founder and leader of the **One Bangsamoro Movement** (**1BANGSA**), a multi-sectoral coalition of activists and community leaders that became one of the most visible Bangsamoro civil society voices in Metro Manila from the ill-fated Memorandum of Agreement on Ancestral Domain (MOA-AD) crisis of 2008 all the way to the successful ratification of the Bangsamoro Organic Law (BOL) in 2019. Where institutions hesitated, Balangi-Amer showed up on the streets, at the negotiating table's edge, and in front of cameras and microphones, carrying the Bangsamoro cause to the heart of the Philippine capital. His story is, at its core, the story of what one determined person from a small town in Lanao can do when conscience refuses to be quiet.

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Also known as	Alan Balangi-Amer; Alan Balang-Amer
Origin	Tamparan, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Ethnicity	Maranao
Nationality	Filipino
Occupation	Peace advocate, human rights defender, civic leader, street parliamentarian
Movement	One Bangsamoro Movement (1BANGSA)
Known for	Two decades of frontline Bangsamoro peace advocacy; founding of 1BANGSA; championing the Bangsamoro Organic Law
Awards	Certificate of Recognition, MSU-Institute of Peace and Development in Mindanao (2019)

Early Life and Background

Balangi-Amer grew up in Tamparan, Lanao del Sur, a rural municipality nestled along the shores of Lake Lanao in the highlands of Mindanao. Tamparan is the kind of place where mornings begin with mist rolling off the lake and the call to prayer drifting across the water, and that environment, deeply Islamic and deeply rooted in Maranao tradition, shaped the man he would become.<ref name="panimbang">Panimbang, G. (n.d.). *Moro activist: 2 decades as frontliner for peace and justice for the Bangsamoro.* REBUILD, Inc.</ref>

Coming from a community that lived with the consequences of the Moro conflict close at hand, Balangi-Amer carried to Manila not just ambition but a clear sense of what he was fighting for. The contrast between the peaceful beauty of his hometown and the decades of armed conflict and political neglect that had scarred the Bangsamoro homeland gave his advocacy its emotional core, a thread he would weave through every rally, forum, and open letter for the next twenty-plus years.

Education and Student Activism

Balangi-Amer's political education began in earnest during his college years in Metro Manila, where he found himself in the middle of a historic opening in the Bangsamoro peace process. When MILF–Government of the Republic of the Philippines (GRP) peace negotiations formally opened in January 1997, the young student from Tamparan was already on the streets, making noise as a street parliamentarian.<ref name="panimbang" />

He rose to become President of the **Integrated Muslim Student Association of the Philippines** (IMUSTAPHIL), one of the most prominent Muslim student organizations in the national capital region. That position gave him a platform, but what he did with it went well beyond student council business. He was the prime mover behind the founding of the **Bangsamoro Youth Peace Advocate** (BYPA), a formation built specifically to channel the voices of Bangsamoro youth and students when President Joseph Estrada's declaration of All-Out War against the MILF in March 2000 threatened to undo the fragile progress of the peace talks.<ref name="panimbang" />

He was also a founding convener of the **Muslim Youth National Assembly** (MYNA), a coalition that became a significant force in the civil society movement that contributed to the ouster of President Estrada in 2001. During this period, Balangi-Amer represented Muslim youth in conferences both in the Philippines and abroad, building a network and a reputation that would serve him well in the harder years ahead.<ref name="panimbang" />

Founding of the One Bangsamoro Movement

The crisis that created 1BANGSA came suddenly. On August 5, 2008, the Supreme Court of the Philippines (http s://sc.judiciary.gov.ph/) issued a Temporary Restraining Order (TRO) blocking the signing of the Memorandum of Agreement on Ancestral Domain (MOA-AD), a landmark agreement that had been years in the making between the MILF and the GRP. Three days later, on August 8, 2008, Balangi-Amer gathered together multi-sectoral leaders and activists and formally established the **One Bangsamoro Movement**, or **1BANGSA**.<ref name="panimbang" />

The timing was not accidental. The MOA-AD's collapse had sent shockwaves through Bangsamoro communities and reignited armed clashes in Mindanao. Balangi-Amer's response was to build a civilian frontline presence in the capital, a group that could lobby, rally, hold press conferences, and keep the peace process alive in public consciousness when political momentum faltered. 1BANGSA was designed from the start not as a fringe protest group but as a broad, credible coalition that could speak to multiple audiences, from government panels to ordinary Filipino citizens.<ref name="panimbang" />

The Long Road to the Bangsamoro Organic Law

Rebuilding After MOA-AD (2008-2012)

After the MOA-AD fell apart and violence flared in Mindanao, many feared the peace process was finished. Balangi-Amer refused to accept that conclusion. As a street parliamentarian, he took on the role of a civilian pressure point, lobbying both the MILF and the GRP to return to the negotiating table. He organized a sustained program of rallies, conferences, fora, and symposiums in Metro Manila, creating what amounted to a continuous public conversation about why the talks had to continue and what was at stake if they did not.<ref name="panimbang" />

That sustained pressure, combined with formal diplomatic efforts, eventually bore fruit. On October 15, 2012, under the administration of Benigno Aquino III, the Framework Agreement on the Bangsamoro (FAB) was signed, giving the peace negotiation a new direction after it had been teetering on the edge of collapse. 1BANGSA and Balangi-Amer had been part of the civilian current that helped keep the talks moving toward that outcome.<ref name="panimbang" />

From FAB to the Comprehensive Agreement (2012-2014)

The FAB was a framework, not a finish line. Balangi-Amer kept 1BANGSA engaged through the years of detailed negotiations that followed, continuing to hold public forums and push for a stronger, more comprehensive agreement. On March 27, 2014, the **Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro** (CAB) was signed, a document that went further than any previous agreement in defining the path toward Bangsamoro political autonomy. The signing prompted the creation of the Bangsamoro Transition Commission (BTC) under the leadership of Mohagher Iqbal, which was mandated to draft what would become the Bangsamoro Basic Law (BBL).<ref name="panimbang" />

The Mamasapano Setback and Interfaith Response (2015)

The peace process hit one of its most painful moments in January 2015, when the Mamasapano clash killed 44 members of the Philippine National Police Special Action Force along with MILF fighters and civilians. The tragedy poisoned the political atmosphere and threatened to kill the BBL before it could be enacted.

Balangi-Amer's response was to look for bridges across the divisions that the tragedy had deepened. He called for an interfaith dialogue that led to an **Interfaith Prayer Rally**, bringing together the Catholic Bishops Conference of the Philippines (CBCP), Iglesia ni Cristo, the Philippine National Police (PNP), and the Armed Forces of the Philippines (AFP) on a shared platform calling for sustained peace in Mindanao. The rally was a signal that peace had supporters who transcended religious and institutional lines, and it helped prevent the Mamasapano tragedy from permanently derailing the legislative process.<ref name="panimbang" />

He also launched the **1 Million Signatures for Bangsamoro** campaign, a signature drive in support of the immediate passage of the BBL, bringing ordinary citizens into an advocacy that had often felt like the exclusive territory of politicians and diplomats.<ref name="panimbang" />

The Duterte Era and the Bangsamoro Organic Law (2016-2019)

When Rodrigo Duterte won the 2016 presidential election, he brought with him a stated commitment to correcting historical injustices against the Bangsamoro. Duterte reconstituted the BTC, expanding it from 15 to 21 commissioners under the late Chairman Ghazali Jaffar, and the strengthened body eventually produced the **Bangsamoro Organic Law** (BOL).<ref name="panimbang" />

For Balangi-Amer and 1BANGSA, the final push for the BOL meant more organizing. During the critical six-day Bicameral Committee Conference on the BOL, he and his group closely monitored the congressional proceedings and organized a motorcade in Metro Manila, staging a press conference alongside the Mindanao Alliance for Peace (MAP) and other groups, calling on the Bicameral Committee to pass the BOL without further delay.<ref name="panimbang" />

Once the BOL was ratified through a plebiscite on January 21, 2019, becoming Republic Act No. 11054, 1BANGSA moved quickly. On February 11, 2019, the organization sent an open letter to President Duterte calling for "fair and equal" appointments to fill the 80 seats of the Bangsamoro Transition Authority (BTA), the interim parliament that would govern the transition from the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (ARMM) to the new Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM).<ref name="panimbang" />

To prepare Bangsamoro communities for the plebiscite, Balangi-Amer led a campaign he called "Kampanya para sa Kaalaman at Pagtalima ng BOL," a public information and advocacy drive to help communities understand the BOL and make an informed choice. And on January 10, 2019, just days before the plebiscite, he convened the **1st 1BANGSA National Leaders Assembly** at the Great Eastern Hotel in Quezon City, gathering 350 leaders from Bangsamoro communities outside the proposed Bangsamoro territory. The assembly was graced by BTC Chairman Ghazali Jaafar and Defense Secretary Delfin Lorenzana, and it sent a powerful signal that support for the BOL extended far beyond Mindanao.<ref name="panimbang" />

Humanitarian Work and Crisis Response

Battle of Marawi (2017)

When the Siege of Marawi began in May 2017, Balangi-Amer joined other leaders in Metro Manila in appealing directly to President Duterte to halt airstrikes, declare a ceasefire, and allow humanitarian groups to reach trapped civilians. He specifically called on authorities not to target mosques (masajids) in the military operations.<ref name="panimbang" />

Beyond appeals, he acted. Under the 1BANGSA program branded "1sang Tulong at Ayuda para sa Bangsamoro," he took an active role in distributing relief goods to Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs) from Marawi, channeling financial assistance worth eight million pesos' worth of relief packages donated by the people of Bulacan.<ref name="panimbang" />

COVID-19 Pandemic Response (2020)

When COVID-19 hit the Philippines, 1BANGSA and Balangi-Amer did not stand aside. In April 2020, the organization wrote directly to President Duterte seeking an extension of the Enhanced Community Quarantine (ECQ) to contain the spread of the pandemic. He and his members set up **Hatid Ginhawa Kontra COVID-19: Tulong at Ayuda para sa Bangsamoro**, a program that provided medical support, psychosocial assistance, legal guidance, and Islamic counselling to Bangsamoro communities, in addition to distributing relief goods.<ref name="panimbang" />

Balangi-Amer also initiated a radio program called **1BANGSA Tayo!** over 94.1 University Radio, using the airwaves to give Bangsamoro listeners accurate, accessible information about COVID-19 at a time when misinformation was rampant.<ref name="panimbang" />

Jolo Cathedral Bombing (2019)

On February 3, 2019, 1BANGSA joined the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF) and the PNP at a prayer rally condemning the bombing of the Cathedral of Our Lady of Mount Carmel in Jolo, Sulu on January 27, 2019, which killed 22 people, and a subsequent blast at a mosque in Zamboanga City that left 2 dead. Balangi-Amer's participation was a deliberate statement that opposition to terrorism was a Bangsamoro value, not just a government talking point.<ref name="panimbang" />

Advocacy Beyond the Peace Process

International Muslim Rights

Balangi-Amer's sense of solidarity with Muslims under threat was never limited to the Philippines. He was vocal in condemning the persecution of Rohingya Muslims in Myanmar, calling on the Myanmar government to provide equal protection of law for Burmese Muslims and urging the international community to bring the mass killings before the International Criminal Court.<ref name="panimbang" />

He also organized rallies and protests expressing solidarity with Muslims in the Middle East who, in his words, were "unjustifiably maltreated and persecuted." That internationalism gave 1BANGSA a moral scope that went beyond domestic politics and connected the Bangsamoro struggle to a broader conversation about justice for Muslim minorities worldwide.<ref name="panimbang" />

Lake Lanao Development

Balangi-Amer's concern for his home region led him to champion the creation of a dedicated government body for Lake Lanao, the massive freshwater lake that supplies an estimated 65 percent of Mindanao's electrical power. He lobbied for the creation of a "Lake Lanao Development Office" under the Office of the President and actively supported a bill creating the **Lake Lanao Development Authority** (LLDA), which was under discussion in the 18th Congress in 2019.<ref name="panimbang" />

His position was straightforward: a lake this critical to Mindanao's energy supply and the livelihoods of Maranao communities around it deserved a dedicated, empowered government institution, not just ad hoc management from multiple agencies.

Recognition and Legacy

The recognition that meant the most to Balangi-Amer came from within the Bangsamoro world itself. The Bangsamoro Transition Commission (BTC), through its Chairman Ghazali Jaffar, formally acknowledged the contributions of 1BANGSA and its leader to the passage of the Bangsamoro Organic Law. The MSU-Institute of Peace and Development in Mindanao (MSU-IPDM) awarded him a Certificate of Recognition in November 2019, during the Mindanao Week of Peace celebrations, for his "exemplary contributions to peacebuilding in Mindanao and relentless pursuit of Human Rights for the Bangsamoro for more than two decades."<ref name="panimbang" /> The certificate was signed by Dr. Akram Latiph, the IPDM's Executive Director at the time.

That citation captures what those who have worked with him tend to say: what distinguishes Balangi-Amer is not just what he achieved, but how long he stayed at it. Two decades is a long time to carry a cause, especially a cause that spent much of those two decades looking like it might never succeed. The MOA-AD collapsed. Mamasapano happened. The BBL stalled. And each time, he came back. Not with bitterness but with another rally, another open letter, another forum, another reason to believe the next chapter would be different.

His story matters for Bangsamoro youth because it demonstrates that sustained civilian pressure, done creatively and persistently, can actually move the needle on national policy. The BOL exists today as a law partly because of street parliamentarians like Balangi-Amer who refused to let the conversation die in the years when it would have been very easy for it to do so.

> "As a man, he was real and religious; as a friend, he was indispensable and true; as a leader, he was example; as a citizen, he was most patriotic; and as a personality, he was dynamic and virtuous." — Prof. Gaphor Panimbang, Executive Director, REBUILD, Inc.<ref name="panimbang" />

See Also

- Bangsamoro Organic Law
- One Bangsamoro Movement
- Moro Islamic Liberation Front
- Bangsamoro Transition Authority
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Lake Lanao
- Siege of Marawi
- Mamasapano clash
- Mohagher Iqbal
- Ghazali Jaffar
- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos

Further Reading

- Panimbang, G. (n.d.). *Moro activist: 2 decades as frontliner for peace and justice for the Bangsamoro.* REBUILD, Inc.
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